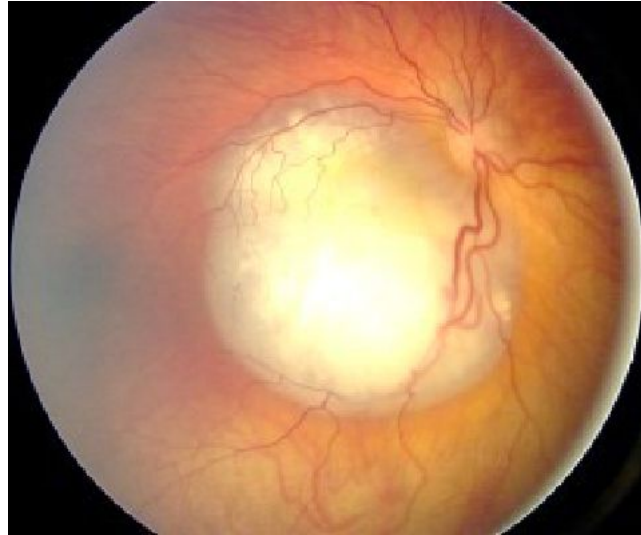


A white pupil can signal a retinal tumour

Leukocoria and a new squint in a young child require urgent ophthalmology assessment.



Retinoblastoma: a white retinal mass obscures vessels and produces an abnormal pupillary reflex.

The urgent differential

Retinoblastoma may present with leukocoria, strabismus or visual inattention. It is a life-threatening childhood intraocular malignancy, so referral should not wait for pain or a striking external abnormality. Treatment depends on stage and extent, with priorities of saving life, then the eye, then vision. A white reflex can also arise from the lens, vitreous or other retinal disease.

Distinguish alternative causes by their anatomy

A fibrovascular stalk and microphthalmia suggest PFV; telangiectasia and exudation suggest Coats disease.

Important alternatives

Pattern	Key finding
Persistent fetal vasculature	Often unilateral; smaller eye with a fibrovascular stalk from disc toward lens.
Coats disease	Often a young boy with unilateral retinal telangiectasia and subretinal exudation.
Congenital cataract	Opacity is in the lens and may deprive the retina of a clear image.
Retinoblastoma	A retinal mass is the principal urgent concern to exclude.

The reflex is a sign, not the diagnosis

Examine both red reflexes and identify the anatomical source of the abnormal reflection. Persistent fetal vasculature follows failed hyaloid vascular regression, while Coats disease involves abnormal leaking retinal vessels. Both differ from a lens opacity or tumour mass. These distinctions guide specialist evaluation; the presence of a plausible alternative does not remove the need for urgent assessment of childhood leukocoria.

References Ashley card 1701584004259; Ashley card 1701588025310; Ashley card 1701582666360; Ashley card 1701576506327